Zachariah and S. Irudaya Rajan over the past two decades. They showed how in a highly educated state with low prospects of employment, migration ‘contributed more to poverty alleviation than any other factor, including agrarian reforms, trade union activities and social welfare legislation’.[43] They estimated that there were over 3 million non-resident Keralites in 2008 and showed how Muslims were over-represented in the migration wave, the variety of occupations the emigrants worked in—from construction to commercial plazas—the social costs of migration in terms of loneliness of the women left behind and, above all, the extent of money and gold that flowed from the Gulf to ‘God’s Own Country’. If Kerala were to be a country, it would rank among the five most remittance-dependent nations in the world as its remittance to GDP ratio stood at a staggering 30 per cent.[44] As I have pointed out, this is not a Kerala-specific story. It applies to the entire west coast below Ratnagiri in internal and international migration streams.

As we go around the tip of the subcontinent, we enter a new world of Tamil mass migration from the coastal plains of Tamil Nadu. Tamil migrations towards South East Asia have a long history but labour migration picked up only in the early 19th century, trotted in the late 19th century and galloped in the early 20th century with over a 1,00,000 people migrating annually. Migration was highly circular and fluctuated as per conditions in destinations as well as local crises such as the Great Famine of 1876–78 that led to a surge in migration volumes.[45] But Ceylon, now called Sri Lanka, Malaya and the Straits Settlements, now part of Malaysia and Singapore, and Burma attracted the bulk of migrations from the Tamil-speaking region. By 1930, Tamils represented around half of all overseas Indians as these three regions hosted nearly 70 per cent of all overseas Indians.[46]

From the southern cluster of districts, earlier called Tanjore, Tinnevely, Madura and Ramnad, migrants would head for Ceylon to work on coffee plantations. After the 1880s, it was tea plantations. From the heartland of the erstwhile Chola Empire that exported martyrs and merchants, labour would now flow at a steady pace to, literally, make tea. Crossing the sea